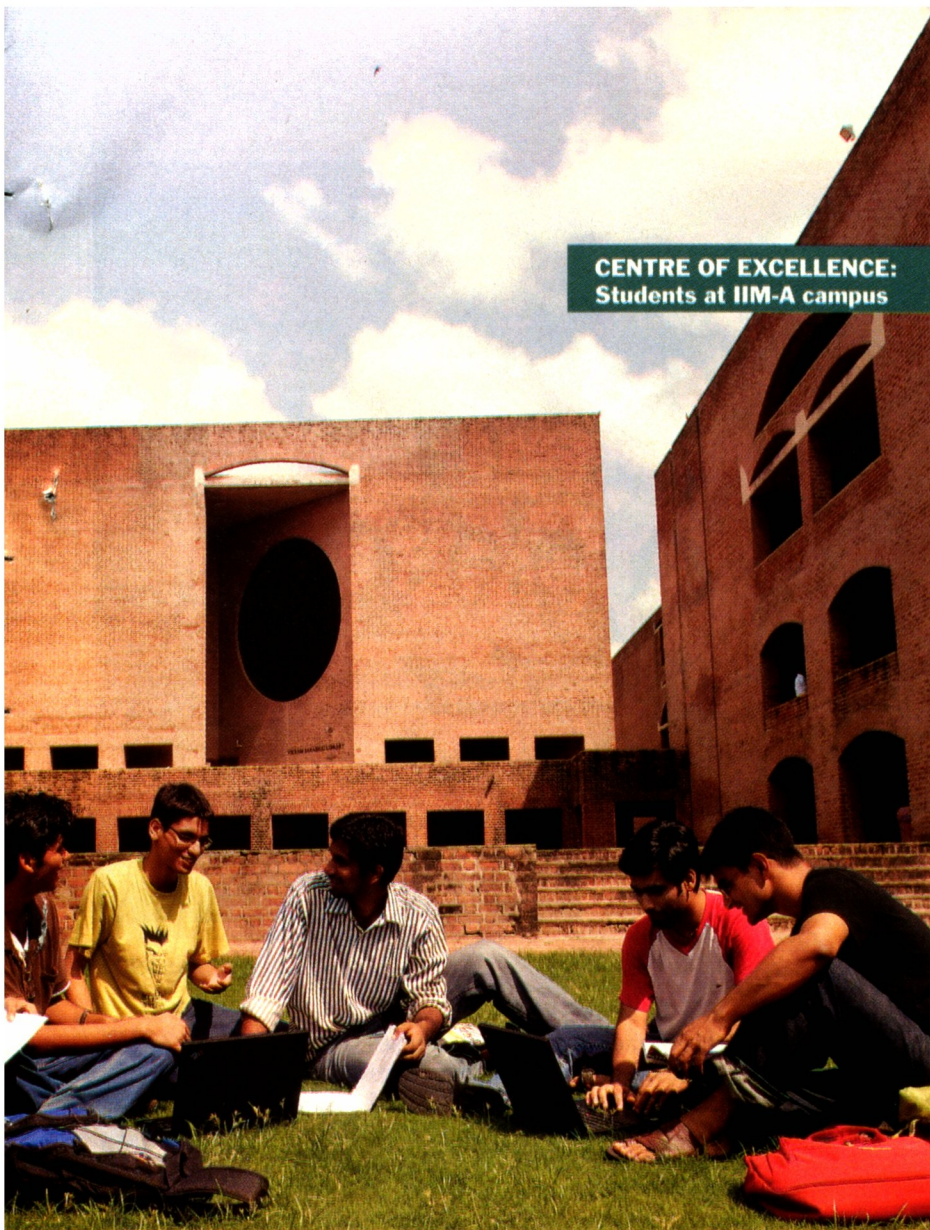


CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE: Students at IIM-A campus



UMESH GOSWAMI

like students, more like junior colleagues. Strange as it may sound in these politically-correct days, smoking in class was permitted and for us, it was a sign that we were being taken seriously as would-be managers.

We were lucky in other ways too. Vikram Sarabhai (who had done India proud in so many ways) would occasionally drop in on the campus and N.R. Narayana Murthy (who would do India proud later) was a young research associate in the Computer Centre where he battled bravely with a giant PDP-11 (a stone-age item for today's students). Louis Kahn, the architect of the campus, visited when we were in Ahmedabad; that was good fortune indeed. The white-haired genius held forth brilliantly.

Over the years, I have been going back: first as a recruiter and more recently as a teacher. The students are definitely brighter or, shall I say, hard-nosed. The campus is bigger. The neighbourhood is congested and auto drivers know where it is. But every time I return, the good old sentimental heart stops for a minute. The magic is still the same.

by Jalithirh (Jerry) Rao

The author belongs to the PGP 1973 batch of IIM-Ahmedabad

KENDRIYA VIDYALAYAS THE FIRST LESSON

Walk into a Kendriya Vidyalaya (KV) and the notion of a dingy ill-equipped government school disintegrates. Big playgrounds, airy classrooms and lesson plans, which have gone beyond the blackboard and chalk to include multimedia tools and IT, have made admission to KVs much sought after. The demand is 10 times the availability of seats, which stands at 10 lakh. Set up for the children of transferable Central Government employees and defence personnel, the schools are also a space where socio-economic boundaries are suspended. The fee structure ex-

empts girls up to Class XII and boys up to Class VIII from payment. But beyond promoting inclusiveness, the KVs also offer excellence in teaching that breaks with the traditional perception of a government school. Says Leila Ben-Nasr, a high school teacher from the US, who as a part of an exchange programme, is teaching in a KV in Delhi, "The discipline in the classrooms is amazing. The real eye-opener is how fluent even primary school children are with English and the poise they show even performing at assembly."

by Deepika Khatri



VIKRAM SHARMA

IRON DISCIPLINE:
Prayer meeting in a KV

Beginning with **20** regimental schools in 1963-64, there are now **981** KVs across the globe.

Rs 994 cr is the budget for all Kendriya Vidyalayas for the year 2006-07.